SOCIOCULTURAL FALSE BELIEF #34 · SUCCESS, STATUS AND MONEY

"I must keep up with everyone around me."

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Where it often comes from

Neighborhood, church, school, workplace, and family can set an unspoken pace: the right house, car, vacation, school, wardrobe. Falling behind feels like being judged. Many carry debt, stress, and exhaustion just to avoid standing out.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, "Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another," and "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves." "Live in harmony with one another. Do not be proud, but enjoy the company of the lowly." Solomon says, "A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones." Hebrews urges, "let us run with endurance the race set out for us," which is our own race, not someone else's. Racing the neighbors is a poor use of the life God has given.

> *"Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another"* (Galatians 5:26).

Also see

> "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves" (Philippians 2:3).

> "Live in harmony with one another. Do not be proud, but enjoy the company of the lowly. Do not be conceited" (Romans 12:16).

> "A tranquil heart is life to the body, but envy rots the bones" (Proverbs 14:30).

> "Therefore, since we are surrounded by such a great cloud of witnesses, let us throw off every encumbrance and the sin that so easily entangles, and let us run with endurance the race set out for us" (Hebrews 12:1).

Common self-statements

- Everyone else has more.
- If I do not keep up, I will be judged.
- I have to match my neighbors.
- I cannot let my family fall behind.
- Slowing down is losing.
- What will people think?

Common logical errors

- Social comparison: Measuring my life by those around me.
- Mind reading: Assuming others judge my standard of living.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should match others.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining disgrace if I do not keep up.

Challenging questions

- Who am I trying to keep up with, and why?
- What is the cost of keeping up in money, time, and peace?
- What would my life look like if I ran my own race?

- What do I truly value, and does my spending match?
- What does Scripture say about envy and humility?
- What is one thing I can stop doing to keep up?

Truth summary

> I am not called to race my neighbors. I can run my own race with endurance, live within my means, and value people over appearances. Peace is worth more than keeping up.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Envy/Jealousy
- Worldly
- Pride
- Dissatisfaction
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Pride
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must keep up with everyone around me"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must keep up with everyone around me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whom am I keeping up with?
- ☐ What does it cost?
- ☐ What are my values?
- ☐ What can I drop?
- ☐ What would my own race look like?
- ☐ What would peace feel like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I run my own race.
- ☐ Envy rots; a tranquil heart gives life.
- ☐ Humility considers others.
- ☐ I can enjoy simple things.
- ☐ Peace is worth more than status.
- ☐ I do not have to match anyone.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Galatians 5:26
  "Let us not become conceited, provoking and envying one another."
- ☐ Philippians 2:3
  "Do nothing out of selfish ambition or empty pride, but in humility consider others more important than yourselves."
- ☐ Hebrews 12:1
  "Therefore, since we are surrounded by such a great cloud of witnesses, let us throw off every encumbrance and the sin that so easily entangles, and let us run with endurance the race set out for us."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] My own race: Each week, note one thing you chose for your values, not for appearances.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Hebrews 12:1 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I will run with endurance the race set out for me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Envy/Jealousy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Name the group. Write who you feel you must keep up with.
- [ ] Count the cost. List what it costs in money, time, and peace.
- [ ] Drop one thing. Stop one expense or activity done for show.
- [ ] Define your values. Write three things that matter most.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must keep up with everyone around me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	My own race
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must keep up with everyone around me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I am tired of keeping up. Help me run my own race, value what You value, and find peace in enough. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.